and don't just blow it on fat-cat salaries. Let's do some number crunching as an example. We have one National Cricket Academy, in Lahore. The Indians have a cricket academy in almost every major city. We can't make even one function properly in four provinces. They have 29 states and at least half of those have international-standard facilities in at least one ground. The Indian talent pool is, therefore, better filtered by the time a player makes it to the international level.

Also, the Indians know how to get the best out of a player. You'd think that once a cricketer has retired and the media has written him off, he would be done with the game. But he's still got other uses. Whoever is cycled out is cycled back in, if he's worth it. Ganguly, Dravid, Kumble: they have been transitioned into consultants. They've become coaches, mentors, even dressing-room big brothers. There are a hundred ways to use your older, wiser stars. India has figured out quite a few solutions in this regard. Good for India.

Meanwhile, on our end, most of the fat cats sitting in the PCB offices have never played the game. They couldn't jog a mile with the boys if they had to. Naturally, they're not going to be inspiring icons. They're only going to subtract, not add value. I won't take names but we all know who these people are. We can spot them from their tailored suits and bulging waistlines.

Sorry, I'm being harsh. But this is cricket. It's my whole life. I've never done anything else but play cricket. Hell, I even dropped out of school because of it. For me, it's simple: the game has to be run by us, the cricketers. This is our game and I'm not going to watch it fade away because of bureaucrats and political appointees. Without a doubt, the system needs an overhaul.

The golden years we pine for – the era of Imran Khan, Zaheer Abbas, Sarfaraz Nawaz, Javed Miandad, Wasim Akram, Waqar Younis – won't return till we create some new legends. One reason I'm sceptical about that happening is due to the lack of great new players. And great new players are not coming on the Pakistani roster because school cricket is dead or almost dying.

Commercialization has a lot to do with it. With the collapse of public education and private schools proliferating, there is not enough attention on sports or other extra-curricular activities. Private schools concentrate on exam preparation and academics. That's it. Public schools are a lost cause but they're the ones with the grounds and the acres. However, nobody wants to go there. If we want to save cricket, we must rebuild school cricket, from the ground up, back to the level in the era when I was playing in, when even ordinary public schools were producing great cricketers.

Parents will have to change their mindset too. When my parents sent me to school, they were open-minded about what I wanted to be. Yes, I didn't hit the books very hard but I was never arm-twisted to focus on becoming a doctor or an engineer (I was roughed around by my father, but he eventually got over it). And even the non-elite, public schools gave you options. If not the best library, public schools at least had very good grounds.

Today, schools are a business. They don't even have proper fields for sports and extra-curricular activities. The privatization wave of educational institutions has a lot to do with this. Schools are like mints now. The private ones are export factories, preparing our kids to go abroad to American and British universities, while the public ones prepare them for local servitude and mediocrity. This has to change. Or else, where will kids start playing organized sport in the first place?

The Pakistani formula for cricket till the recent commercialization of school education, much